Perfect Pie

By Judith Thompson

(School yard – Marie scratches her head while looking at the ground)

PATSY: **(Pg 13-14)** Where do you come from anyways?

MARIE: Detroit. My dad he grew up here but then they lost the Farm, cause our well run dry and so he went to work makin' cars in Detroit but he hurt his back and my Gramma took a stroke an left us the house so we come back.

PATSY: How old are you?

MARIE: Nine. My birthday was in August. August 23rd

PATSY: Oh my GOSH mine is January 23rd! That's amazing. Maybe you could come to my birthday party. We'll play musical chairs and my mother, she plays the piano? She's singin' and then when she stops? Like you have to sit in a chair, and . . .

(Patsy jumps into a "freeze" position. Marie expresses acceptance, joy)

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS 1: *Patsy and Marie meet as children and become fast friends, despite their differences.*
ACTRESS 2: *Together they deal with poverty, their parents, bullies and puberty.*
ACTRESS 1: *But at 15, a Sadie Hawkins Dance changes everything.*
TOGETHER: *Perfect Pie by Judith Thompson*

PATSY: **(Pg 19)** Are you poor? You look poor. I mean only a little. Just the scabs on your legs. . . **(Pg 22)** Are you on welfare?

MARIE: No. Who told you that?

PATSY: Patty Hagerty. I told them that was not a nice thing to say. "If you can't say anything nice don't say anything at all." That's what my mother always says . . . **(Pg 25-26)** you have lice.

MARIE: No I don't

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PATSY: Yes you do. I saw one. Crawling on your head. This morning 'cause you were sittin' in front of me. *(Marie has a defiant and shocked expression on her face)* Honest. I did. I know what they look like 'cause my brother had them once. The Welfares brought them into the school.

MARIE: I do not have lice.

PATSY: *(Pause)* I could show you a special way to get rid of them. Then they would be all gone.

MARIE: My mother won't buy the shampoo. She says they're not lice they're bedbugs.

PATSY: That's okay. Don't you worry 'bout a THING. I'll get rid of 'em for you. I know this REALLY special way. I'll show you. You come over to my house, after school, okay?

*******Scene break********

(First sleepover. Patsy is standing behind Marie, picking nits. She wears gloves)

PATSY: **(Pg 29)** Seventy-nine. Eighty.

MARIE: Holy Crow. Don't tell nobody, eh?

PATSY: Eighty-one.

MARIE: My mother won't do this. She says no child of hers has lice.

PATSY: I don't mind doin' it. I like it! Eighty-two.

MARIE: Sometimes, at night? I'm lyin' in bed and the itchiness is so bad I think I'm just gonna jump out a window and run down the street screaming.

TRANSITION

ACTRESS 1: *As with all children . . . Patsy and Marie grew up . . .*
ACTRESS 2: *Patsy became a domestic goddess, steering clear of the big wide world.*
ACTRESS 1: *And Marie changed her name to Francesca and left town to become a somewhat successful actor.*
ACTRESS 2: *After 15 years apart, the two reunite at Patsy's home and begin to reminisce*
ACTRESS 1: *But as this powerful play nears its end, we realize it is not a play about nostalgia at all*

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PATSY: **(Pg 32-33)** Does it still bother you, when you think about it? The way you were treated as a kid?

FRANCESCA: Sometimes in a flash I am eleven years old again and they're throwing stones at me. Calling me those names and coughing. Remember? They used to cough when they saw me.

PATSY: Ignorant dogs.

FRANCESCA: On my bad days I think it was something in me. Something they detected? Something that is . . . still there. You know? There was a reason they picked on me, and not Darlene Rowan, who was also poor

PATSY: Because Darlene, she knew her place, right? She never raised her head!

FRANCESCA: So I walk out of my beautiful penthouse on the 20th floor feeling this big kind of Dirty Yellow Stain all over me. The Marie Begg Stain. I go to dinner parties, book launches and I feel that people are avoiding the Stain. I see their eyes wandering and I feel the others are whispering about me, and then I think I hear them coughing. And again, I am the girl with the running sores and the scabby legs, the lice and the dark circles under her eyes and the crooked teeth. I am Marie Begg. With the Stain.

PATSY: Well, you look pretty clean to me, if it's any comfort. **(Pg 20)** Maybe you just weren't ready for this place. That's what I been tellin' myself all these years, anyways. *(Francesca is puzzled)* . . . Why you woulda done what you did.

FRANCESCA: Abandoned you.

PATSY: Didn't dare to look back. **(Pg 44)** I was in a coma for eight weeks, Francesca. Nothing was the same when I come out. **(pg 20-21)** When I woke up first thing I say, I go, "Where's Marie? Where's Marie?" I prayed for you, thinking you were dead or being tortured somewhere. I mean I didn't know if you were even alive until I read about you in the paper, ten years later.

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FRANCESCA: I stayed in Buffalo, for six months, on the street. Then, in Albany, New York. I remember being at a boyfriend's, a much older guy, in his thirties. He said I could call anywhere I wanted and I dialed your number, but I hung up before it rang. I did that about twenty times.

PATSY: When I come out of my coma you had already been gone three weeks. **(Pg 54)** The crash left me with a big bag of bothers. Still can't move my left hand well. Can't walk fast, can't run at all. And you know the weirdest thing? Can't cry. Haven't cried since before the crash . . . . **(Pg 21 22)** Your mother, she wouldn't open the door for me; she screamed that the whole thing was all my fault. I was a tramp and a bad influence. I went to the police and they said you were a runaway, and you were almost sixteen so there was nothing they could do.

FRANCESCA: I remember sitting in Buffalo, 15 years old, eating onion rings, with money I'd begged, and – knowing – deep – in – my – stomach – that nobody was . . . ever coming after me. *(Patsy goes to Francesca)*

PATSY: I always felt if I hadda told them . . About everything . . . You know. Like what . . . happened . . . then they woulda gone after you. *(Francesca moves away as the mention of "what happened" fills her with terror).* After what you had . . . you know . . . oh . . . I'm sorry. You don't want to talk about it. I just wish that you would had called me, you know. I mean what . . what were you . . . afraid of? *(Francesca turns away)*

*******Scene break********

(Pg 68-70) *(Girls are bushing dog poop off Marie's coat)*

MARIE: If somebody would just tell me why they are doing this to me, I would be their slave for life. What is WRONG with me. I know I'm not UGLY, aside from my face. I do really well in school, I'm nice. I mean what the hell is wrong with me?

PATSY: Well. Maybe . . if you had . . . a . . . .

MARIE: What? *(long pause)*

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PATSY: Bath? I mean, no offense or anything, and it doesn't bother me at all, but I was just thinking that maybe if you like, took a bath or a shower more.

MARIE: I smell? Really? But I wash under my arms with soap every day. I couldn't smell. You're crazy. *(Patsy shrugs)* Why didn't you tell me this before?

PATSY: *(Shrugs again)* My mom says that when you reach puberty all these strange smells start to happen and well that you need to take a bath once a week.

MARIE: See the thing is . . I want to take a bath, right. But the last time I filled the bath my Mum gave me a black eye 'cause we don't have hardly any water in our well. *(long pause)* **(Pg 74-75)** I'm the town dog, Patsy. *(Marie barks)*

PATSY: Stop it. That is not true. *(Marie tries to think of something positive to say to lighten the mood)*

MARIE: Donny Neilson talked to me today.

PATSY: No way. I've never seen him talk to a girl.

MARIE: He was talking about how he plays hockey. How he plays every day for hours and hours. He said he dreams about hockey.

PATSY: He said all of that? To you? *(Marie nods)* Well, the Sadie Hawkins dance is comin' up. Why don't you ask him?

*******Scene break********

(PG 76-77) *Getting ready for the dance.*

PATSY: Now, with the mascara, you brush over the eyelashes three times. And you have to wipe the wand off so it doesn't get all goopy and make you look like white trash. *(Steps back to look at Marie)* Oh my god your hair is perfect. You look like Miss America. *(Marie goes to touch her hair)* Don't touch it. *(Marie goes to touch it)* DON'T TOUCH it!

MARIE: I wish you were coming.

PATSY: Oh, this flu is so bad I can hardly see straight.

MARIE: What do I do if he kisses me, Patsy?

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PATSY: You just kiss back. But gently. And above all do not let him feel you up. You know what they think of sluts around here. Look at Darlene Rowan.

MARIE: Yeah. . . .

PATSY: You just slap his hand, hard. And make sure everybody sees ya. *(Takes her to a mirror)* You are gonna be the prettiest girl at the dance. And they're all gonna go like, "What happened to Marie Begg? I mean like where is Marie Begg?

*******Scene break********

(Present day) **(Pg 78-89)**

FRANCESCA: I had worn that green dress you made me

PATSY: Yes you did . . . And I had brushed your hair until it shimmered. . . You looked beautiful.

FRANCESCA: I looked beautiful. I waited for him on the steps of the Kentucky Fried Chicken. And then there he was . . . we walked and he actually held my hand. I almost fainted. I had never been touched by a boy you see. We went into the gym with the streamers and the punch bowl. He was still holding my hand, but the others, Pat Letour and Roly and them, they stared and after a while, they started to cough. They were laughing at him and there was that moment when he knew he was being laughed at . . . because of me. He suddenly knew I was the school dog. He hadn't realized, you see. COUGHING . . . because he was from St. Mike's, so . . . so, he shook off my hand and, and, and . . .

PATSY: And then what, Marie? What happened then?

FRANCESCA: He never came back. I waited by the wall and I waited. And they stared and they gathered and they threw spitballs and he never came back. I walked out. My head down, my legs shaking, across the football field. In my mother's high heels . . . And they were suddenly there. Pat, Roland, Mike and Jamie and they pushed me from behind and they were laughing. And saying my hair looked nice. And all their hands, their fingers, touching me. I tried to walk past them.

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But someone grabbed my arms. So hard. They kept laughing. And coughing. Their saliva spraying on my face and saying dirty words, filthy words I didn't understand. And then I fell backwards and them all unzipping their pants and then wham! I could feel the spraying on my face, and see their faces . . . the sound, the spraying, the SMELL Ohhhhhhh, Patsy, the SMELL . . . *(Francesca collapses and relives the memory)*

*******Scene break********

(Patsy is making an apple pie while she waits for Marie to get home from the dance. Her back is to Marie who enters – she is shaking uncontrollably and her teeth are chattering. Her dress is covered in mud and ripped. There is blood)

MARIE: Patsy?

PATSY: How was it? Gimme all the dirt. I want every detail. *(Turns to Marie)* Holy God. What happened to you? *(Marie cannot answer. She sits down, trembling, shaky. Patsy approaches her. Marie smells terrible of urine)* Aww. *(She gags)* Marie?! Marie, have you peed your pants Marie? What happened to you? *(Marie doesn't answer)* Marie. You're shaking. Did you get hit by a car or something? Where's Donny? Did he drop you off here?

MARIE: I walked from town.

PATSY: You walked! That's ten miles, Marie. Look at you, you're barefoot, where are your shoes, Marie?

MARIE: Is it true about Holly French? . . . That she does that all the time? She does that with all of them . . . That's what they said. *(Marie begins to walk in circles around the room, speaking in a low continuous mutter)* She does it all the time . . . all the cute girls do. Really really you gotta trust us: Okay, are you sure? Really is that true that all the cute girls do this? Really I don't believe you guys, you guys are teasing me. Oh yeah, yeah, baby, promise promise on my mother's life, right here by the goalpost. Every dance Holly and Carol and

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Nancy. We'll be gentle, come on, you are so pretty. We'll be gentle. Me pretty? We have always liked your legs . . . such nice long legs let us see your legs . . . pull up the dress. You can come to all our games now, Marie, and party after. Would you like to come with us and party . . . hard? "YOU DOG. TURN OVER YOU DOG. I'LL SCREW YOU TO DEATH" And barking and coughing and barking. "TURN OVER BITCH!" *(Marie runs from the house; Patsy is stunned, silent, devastated, then rushes to follow Marie.)*

*******Scene break********

(Marie has left the house and climbed up the hill to the railroad tracks)

PATSY: Marie!! Wait up, wait up! Marie, where ya goin'? You're not thinkin' of doin' something stupid are ya?

MARIE: I'm waiting for the train, Patsy.

PATSY: Train doesn't stop here, Marie. Only stops in Belleville.

MARIE: It will stop for me. . . Goin' away now.

PATSY: Marie, if you don't get down from there the train is going to hit you.

MARIE: The train will stop for me. It will stop for both of us, Patsy. Come on, Come with me. *(Motions for Patsy to join her on the tracks)*

PATSY: Just come on down from there and we'll go to the police. It's the right thing to do Marie.

MARIE: Patsy . . . I'm scared.

PATSY: *(hears the train whistle in the distance)* Marie you come offa this track. I think I hear something. Marie! *(Marie stretches her hands towards the direction the train will be coming from. Patsy tries to pull Marie off -- Adult Patsy steps out of the scene and voices the next lines in memory)* And . . . and the train is coming, I can feel it in my feet and I pull . . . and I pull . . . wanna save my friend . . . and then . . . I can't explain it, but suddenly I looked at the moon and I thought, "Yeah Me and Marie, me and Marie. *(Young Patsy climbs back on the tracks behind Marie)* "We

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are gonna die beautiful, we are gonna fly through the sky." *(Adult Patsy)* And I held your hand . . . *(both hold up theirs hands in the light of the approaching train until at the last moment, Marie's thinking clears, she gets off the tracks and tries to pull Patsy off)* And YOU are pullin' on me. Pullin' away, but I am not gonna let you go. I am going to stay on this track. Then I feel it. I feel it in my feet and *(Both girls fly through the air to the ground in a heap)* We flew. You saved my life, Marie.

FRANCESCA: No . . . No . . . no we were there together and we both wanted to fly away, that's all we wanted, to – fly away. *(Long pause . . . then Marie finally confesses to Patsy)* **(Pg 37)** Lying in that hospital bed for all those weeks, with broken bones, I stared at the ceiling and I knew how I would end up if I stayed. I would end up the way they all thought of me. You can't keep fighting the way people think of you, eventually, you have to give into it, and become it. And that's when I decided that I was going to leave Marie behind . . . and I was never ever going to come back.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Judith Thompson
ISBN: 978-0887545900
Publisher: Playwrights Canada Press
Date (Month/Year): 2000

AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier